

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Extreme heat

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move to air conditioning or a designated cooling space, reduce exertion and drink water regularly unless your clinician restricts fluids. Confusion, collapse or seizures in heat can mean heat stroke: call emergency services and start rapid cooling.

Do now.

**Find a cooler place**

01

Use air conditioning, a public cooling center or another safe indoor location.

**Reduce heat load**

02

Rest, loosen unnecessary clothing and use cool wet cloths or a cool shower.

**Check on others**

03

Older adults, infants, outdoor workers and people with illness may need help. Never leave anyone or pets in a parked vehicle.

**Recognize an emergency**

04

For altered mental status or collapse, call emergency services and cool the person while waiting; do not give drinks to someone unable to swallow.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the coolest reachable space, wet skin or cloths, reduce activity and check vulnerable people repeatedly. A closed room can become more dangerous than outdoor shade. If indoor heat becomes intolerable, move early to a safer location rather than waiting for power to return.

Watch for.

Heat stroke can occur with sweating. Do not wait for dry skin.

People & practical needs.

Check infants, older adults and people taking medicines that affect heat tolerance. Share the cooling plan in a form everyone can understand and name a person responsible for check-ins. Do not treat a fan or closed-window plan as suitable at every temperature.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Plan activities for cooler hours and follow heat alerts. Arrange safe transport before the home becomes dangerously hot.

Check the next usable option

Plan activities for cooler hours and follow heat alerts. Arrange safe transport before the home becomes dangerously hot.

When the first option is unavailable

Use the coolest reachable space, wet skin or cloths, reduce activity and check vulnerable people repeatedly. A closed room can become more dangerous than outdoor shade. If indoor heat becomes intolerable, move early to a safer location rather than waiting for power to return.

Questions in the field.

Is confusion just tiredness?

Confusion, collapse or other serious neurological changes in heat can indicate heat stroke and require urgent medical help plus immediate cooling. Do not give drinks to someone who is not fully awake or cannot swallow.

The cooling center is closed - what now?

Check another cooler location and reduce exertion while arranging access. Confirm opening and transport before relying on a listed center. Do not leave a person in a vehicle while trying to solve the next step.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Extreme heat · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/heat>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/extreme-heat/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.